

FILM MAKING AND RADIO PODCASTING CD23731

REPORT

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**RAJALAKSHMI ENGINEERING COLLEGE
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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

Film making is a form of visual communication that combines storytelling, acting, cinematography, lighting, sound and editing to communicate an idea or emotional experience. A short film presents a complete narrative within a limited duration, making it necessary to develop a focused concept and use each visual and auditory element purposefully.

The project titled **The Empty Bench** is a psychological mystery short film developed as part of the Film Making and Radio Podcasting course. The film follows a lonely student who receives the message “You're late. Same place.” and returns to a familiar bench in a garden. He behaves as though another person is present, although the audience never sees that person.

The narrative gradually connects the present with an earlier loss. An old photograph, a warning in a notebook and a phone call using the protagonist's own voice create uncertainty about what is real. The film deliberately avoids confirming whether the protagonist is communicating with a memory, experiencing a psychological perception, encountering another version of himself, or experiencing something supernatural.

The project is intentionally designed with one actor, two locations, minimal dialogue and limited production requirements. Visual storytelling, empty space, silence, facial expressions and recurring framing are therefore central to the communication of the story.

CHAPTER 2

PROJECT OVERVIEW

The main idea of **The Empty Bench** is to explore how attachment to a person can continue even after that person is no longer present. The story begins with an apparently simple invitation and gradually introduces details that challenge the protagonist's understanding of the situation.

The garden bench functions as the central visual location. It is both a physical place and a representation of memory. The empty space beside the protagonist is repeatedly shown so that the audience becomes aware of the absence without being shown a definite supernatural figure.

The film uses the protagonist's limited perspective. Instead of explaining the past through lengthy dialogue, information is revealed through the photograph, notebook, phone messages, voice recording and his reactions. This approach supports the psychological mystery genre while keeping the production practical.

Project Element	Details
Film Title	The Empty Bench
Genre	Psychological Mystery
Duration	Approximately 3 minutes
Format	Short film
Cast	One actor
Locations	Hostel and garden
Primary Themes	Loss, memory, attachment, reality vs. perception
Dialogue Style	Minimal
Ending	Ambiguous and intentionally unresolved

CHAPTER 3

TITLE – THE EMPTY BENCH

The title **The Empty Bench** refers directly to the most important recurring image in the film. The protagonist repeatedly occupies one side of a bench while the other side remains empty.

The bench represents the absence of the person connected with the protagonist's past. At the same time, the empty space can be interpreted as a visual representation of memory, attachment or perception. The title therefore describes both a physical object and the emotional condition explored by the story.

The title also supports the film's ambiguous ending. Even when the protagonist returns to the bench, the audience still does not receive visual confirmation that another person is present. The empty space remains the central unanswered image.

CHAPTER 4

GENRE

The film belongs to the **psychological mystery** genre. The mystery is developed through incomplete information and uncertainty rather than through a conventional visible antagonist.

The psychological element comes from the protagonist's relationship with memory and loss. His actions suggest that the past remains emotionally active in the present. The audience is encouraged to question whether the events are external or are being experienced through the protagonist's perception.

The major mystery elements used in the film are:

- The unexplained message: "You're late. Same place."
- The protagonist behaving as though someone is sitting beside him.
- The old photograph from three years earlier.
- The warning: "DON'T GO BACK TO THE BENCH."
- The instruction: "IF HE CALLS, DON'T ANSWER."
- The unknown caller using the protagonist's own voice.
- The statements "You already know" and "That's what you remember."
- The empty space beside the protagonist in the final scene.

CHAPTER 5

OBJECTIVES

The main objective of the project is to create a short psychological mystery film using a simple production setup while demonstrating purposeful visual storytelling, sound design, cinematography and editing.

The specific objectives are:

- To develop an original short-film concept based on loss, memory and attachment.
- To construct a mystery without directly explaining the source of the events.
- To practice screenplay and scene development within an approximately three-minute duration.
- To use a single actor effectively through facial expressions, body language and limited dialogue.
- To use the empty bench and surrounding negative space as recurring visual motifs.
- To use camera framing to distinguish ordinary moments from psychologically uncertain moments.
- To create atmosphere through natural ambience, pauses and subtle music.
- To use editing to control the release of information and preserve ambiguity.
- To understand the practical challenges of producing a short film with minimal locations and cast.

CHAPTER 6

STORY DEVELOPMENT

The story was developed from the idea that emotional attachment can continue after a person is physically absent. The first narrative requirement was therefore to create a situation in which the protagonist behaves as though he is meeting someone, while the audience is never given a direct view of that person.

The opening message, “You’re late. Same place.” provides a simple reason for the protagonist to visit the garden without immediately explaining who sent it. The familiar bench then establishes a connection with the past.

The story was structured so that information is revealed in stages. The bench creates the initial question; the photograph establishes the history; the notebook warnings increase uncertainty; and the unknown call connects the mystery directly to the protagonist’s identity.

The final exchange was designed to avoid a single interpretation. The statement “That’s what you remember” challenges the protagonist’s certainty without explaining the truth. The narrative therefore ends at the point where interpretation becomes part of the audience experience.

Development Stage	Narrative Function
Initial message	Creates the reason to return to the bench.
Garden meeting	Establishes the unseen presence and emotional attachment.
Old photograph	Connects the present situation with the past.
Notebook warnings	Introduces danger and uncertainty.
Unknown call	Links the mystery to the protagonist’s own identity.
Final bench scene	Returns to the central image and preserves ambiguity.

CHAPTER 7

STORY SYNOPSIS

A lonely student receives a mysterious message: **“You're late. Same place.”** He goes to a familiar bench in a garden and sits down. He behaves as though someone is sitting beside him, although the audience never sees another person.

His dialogue is limited to a few lines: “Sorry.”, “I know.” and “Tomorrow?” The simplicity of the exchange leaves the nature of the relationship unexplained.

Later, back in the hostel, he discovers an old photograph showing himself at the same bench with someone from three years earlier. He then finds an old notebook containing the warnings “DON'T GO BACK TO THE BENCH.” and “IF HE CALLS, DON'T ANSWER.”

His phone rings from an unknown number. When he answers, the voice is his own voice. The voice says, “Don't go tomorrow.” He asks, “Who are you?” and receives the reply, “You already know.”

In the final garden scene, he returns to the bench. The caller says, “You're late.” The protagonist responds, “You died three years ago.” The voice replies, “That's what you remember.” He sits on the bench. The space beside him remains empty.

The film ends without confirming whether the protagonist is communicating with a memory, experiencing a psychological perception, hearing another version of himself, or encountering something supernatural. This uncertainty is an intentional part of the narrative.

CHAPTER 8

CHARACTERS

The film is designed around one visible actor. The protagonist carries the emotional and narrative responsibility of the film. His expressions, pauses, eye movements, posture and interaction with empty space communicate information that would normally be distributed across multiple characters.

The person associated with the protagonist's past is never physically shown. This is an intentional narrative choice, not an omitted cast member. The character exists through the protagonist's memory, the old photograph, the dialogue and the mysterious voice.

Character	Presence in Film	Function
Protagonist	Visible; played by one actor	Carries the narrative and emotional experience.
Unseen person / voice	Never physically shown	Represents the unresolved past and supports the mystery.

Because only one actor appears on screen, performance must be controlled and understated. The protagonist should not immediately display fear; the emotional shift should develop through small reactions as the evidence becomes more difficult to understand.

CHAPTER 9

SCENE DEVELOPMENT

9.1 Scene 1 – The Message The film opens with the protagonist receiving the message “You're late. Same place.” The phone becomes the first story clue. A restrained reaction is preferable to an exaggerated response so that the audience remains uncertain about the meaning of the message.

9.2 Scene 2 – The Garden Bench The protagonist reaches the familiar bench and sits. The camera establishes the empty space beside him. He behaves as though another person is present. The dialogue is minimal: “Sorry.”, “I know.” and “Tomorrow?” Long pauses and natural ambience carry much of the scene.

9.3 Scene 3 – Return to the Hostel Back in the hostel, the protagonist discovers an old photograph of himself at the same bench with someone from three years earlier. The photograph provides the first concrete connection between the present and the past.

9.4 Scene 4 – The Notebook The protagonist finds an old notebook. The warning “DON'T GO BACK TO THE BENCH.” is followed by “IF HE CALLS, DON'T ANSWER.” The camera should allow the audience to read the words without requiring explanatory dialogue.

9.5 Scene 5 – The Unknown Call The phone rings from an unknown number. The protagonist answers. The voice is his own voice and says, “Don't go tomorrow.” He asks, “Who are you?” The answer, “You already know,” increases the uncertainty about identity and memory.

9.6 Scene 6 – The Final Return The protagonist returns to the garden. The caller says, “You're late.” The protagonist says, “You died three years ago.” The voice replies, “That's what you remember.” He sits on the bench and the film ends with the space beside him empty.

Table 9.1 – Scene Breakdown

Scene	Location	Key Action	Primary Purpose
1	Hostel	Receives message	Introduce mystery.
2	Garden	Sits at bench	Establish unseen presence.
3	Hostel	Finds photograph	Connect present to past.

4	Hostel	Reads notebook	Increase uncertainty.
5	Hostel	Answers unknown call	Question identity and reality.

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Scene	Location	Key Action	Primary Purpose
6	Garden	Returns to bench	Deliver ambiguous ending.

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CHAPTER 10

CLIMAX AND ENDING

The climax occurs through the unknown phone call and the final return to the bench. The use of the protagonist's own voice changes the nature of the mystery. The caller is not presented simply as an external stranger; instead, the voice creates uncertainty about identity and perception.

The final dialogue is the key narrative reversal. When the protagonist states, "You died three years ago," the audience is given a possible explanation for the photograph and the attachment. However, the response, "That's what you remember," immediately prevents that explanation from becoming definitive.

The final image returns to the same bench used earlier. The protagonist sits while the space beside him remains empty. This visual repetition connects the beginning and ending of the garden storyline.

The ending intentionally does not establish a single truth. Possible interpretations include communication with a memory, a psychological perception, another version of the protagonist, or a supernatural event. The film does not select one interpretation.

CHAPTER 11

CINEMATOGRAPHY

Cinematography is used to guide attention toward the protagonist and the empty space around him. Since the film contains one actor, composition becomes especially important for suggesting an unseen relationship.

Wide and medium shots can establish the garden and bench while preserving the empty area beside the protagonist. Medium close-ups and close-ups can then capture facial reactions, the phone, the photograph and the notebook.

The first and final garden scenes should visually mirror each other. Similar framing, camera height and screen position can create a visual loop. The difference is that the audience understands more about the protagonist's past by the final scene.

Over-the-shoulder or insert shots can be used for the phone, photograph and notebook. These shots reveal information without requiring additional characters.

Shot Type	Application
Wide shot	Establish garden, bench and empty space.
Medium shot	Show the protagonist sitting and interacting with the unseen presence.
Close-up	Capture facial expressions and emotional changes.
Insert shot	Show message, photograph and notebook warnings.
Repeated framing	Mirror the opening and final bench scenes.

CHAPTER 12

LIGHTING

Lighting should support the psychological tone without making the film visually dependent on artificial horror effects. The hostel can use a practical and familiar lighting arrangement, while the garden can rely on available natural or ambient light appropriate to the shooting conditions.

The visual objective is to maintain a sense of realism while allowing empty areas of the frame to remain visually important. The audience should be able to see the bench and surrounding space clearly enough to recognize that no second person is shown.

Lighting continuity is important because the first and final garden scenes are intended to mirror each other. Any differences in time of day or available light should be controlled during production where possible.

Specific lighting equipment is not assumed in this report. The exact camera and lighting equipment used for production should be documented as **[TO BE PROVIDED]** if required by the final submission.

CHAPTER 13

SOUND DESIGN

Sound is a major storytelling element in **The Empty Bench** because the film intentionally uses very little dialogue. Natural ambience can communicate the physical environment while silence can emphasize emotional and psychological uncertainty.

The garden scenes can include natural environmental sound. In contrast, the hostel scenes can use subtle room ambience. The phone message and ringtone provide important narrative cues because they introduce information without another visible character.

The mysterious voice is performed using the protagonist's own voice. This is important because it creates uncertainty about whether the call originates outside the protagonist or within his own perception.

Music should remain subtle and atmospheric. Silence should be deliberately preserved around the empty bench, the notebook warnings and the final revelation rather than filling every moment with background music.

Important sound elements include:

- Natural garden ambience.
- Hostel room ambience.
- Message notification.
- Phone ringtone.
- Controlled pauses and silence.
- Minimal atmospheric background music.
- The protagonist's recorded voice used as the mysterious caller.
- Room and movement sounds where naturally captured.

CHAPTER 14

EDITING TECHNIQUES

Editing controls how quickly the audience receives information. Since the film is approximately three minutes long, the edit must remain economical and avoid unnecessary exposition.

Hard cuts are appropriate for moving between the garden and hostel. Longer holds can be used when the protagonist sits at the bench so that the empty space becomes noticeable.

Insert shots of the photograph and notebook can be placed at precise moments to reveal information. The warnings should be readable but should not be accompanied by excessive visual effects.

The final scene can return to a framing similar to the opening garden scene. The repeated image creates structural continuity while the dialogue changes the audience's understanding of the bench.

Editing should avoid a definite visual reveal of a ghost or other supernatural figure. The ambiguity depends on what the film chooses not to show.

Editing Method	Purpose
Hard cuts	Maintain a direct, economical rhythm.
Long pauses	Allow emotional reactions and empty space to register.
Insert cuts	Reveal phone, photograph and notebook information.
Visual repetition	Connect first and final garden scenes.
Minimal transitions	Maintain realism and avoid unnecessary stylistic distraction.

CHAPTER 15

USE OF PROPS AND LOCATION

The project intentionally uses only two primary locations: a hostel and a garden. The limited locations reduce production complexity and allow the story to focus on the protagonist's internal experience.

The garden bench is the central physical element. It represents the place associated with the protagonist's memory and provides a consistent composition for the beginning and ending.

The hostel functions as the investigation space where the protagonist discovers evidence from the past.

Item / Location	Use in Film	Narrative Importance
Garden bench	Meeting place and final location	Represents memory, absence and attachment.
Hostel room	Investigation and phone-call scenes	Provides private space for discovering the past.
Mobile phone	Message and unknown call	Introduces and develops the mystery.
Old photograph	Found in hostel	Connects protagonist with the past.
Old notebook	Contains warnings	Creates a sense of prior knowledge and danger.

CHAPTER 16

PRODUCTION PROCESS

The production process can be divided into three stages: pre-production, production and post-production. Each stage is important because the film relies on controlled pacing and repeated visual composition.

Pre-production: The story concept, screenplay, scene order, locations, props and dialogue are identified. The final garden scene is planned alongside the opening garden scene so that their visual relationship can be maintained.

Production: The scenes are recorded at the hostel and garden. The actor's performance is captured with attention to facial expressions, pauses, body language and interaction with the empty space. Multiple takes may be required to maintain continuity.

Post-production: The footage is organized and edited into the approximately three-minute narrative. Sound, ambience, the mysterious voice, phone content and final pacing are refined before export.

Stage	Main Activities	Status
Pre-production	Concept, screenplay, scene planning, props and locations	[TO BE PROVIDED]
Production	Hostel and garden filming; one-actor performance	[TO BE PROVIDED]
Post-production	Editing, sound, voice, review and export	[TO BE PROVIDED]

CHAPTER 17

POST-PRODUCTION WORKFLOW

The post-production workflow is designed around narrative clarity and controlled ambiguity. The first step is to organize the recorded material according to scene order. Unusable takes and unnecessary repetitions are removed.

The second stage is the rough cut. The opening message, first bench scene, hostel discovery, phone call and final return are arranged so that the story remains understandable without adding explanatory dialogue.

The next stage focuses on pacing. Pauses are retained where the audience needs time to observe the protagonist or the empty space. The final pause after the protagonist sits on the bench is especially important.

Sound is then balanced with the dialogue and mysterious voice. The final export settings and editing software used for the actual project should be documented as **[TO BE PROVIDED]** rather than assumed.

Post-production Step	Purpose
Footage organization	Arrange material by scene and take.
Rough cut	Establish complete story order.
Pacing refinement	Control pauses, cuts and reveal timing.
Sound editing	Add ambience, dialogue, voice and silence.
Final review	Check continuity, readability and ambiguity.
Export	Create final short-film file using actual project settings.

CHAPTER 18

FINAL OUTPUT AND EVALUATION

The intended final output is an approximately three-minute psychological mystery short film titled **The Empty Bench**. The final work should communicate its central theme through visual and auditory choices rather than through extensive exposition.

The film can be evaluated using practical criteria such as narrative clarity, consistency of the visual motif, quality of the single-actor performance, effectiveness of sound, editing rhythm and preservation of the intended ambiguity.

Evaluation Area	Expected Observation
Story	The sequence of events is understandable while the central mystery remains unresolved.
Performance	The actor communicates emotion primarily through expression and controlled reactions.
Cinematography	The bench and empty space remain visually significant.
Sound	Ambience, voice and silence support the psychological tone.
Editing	The approximately three-minute duration is maintained without unnecessary scenes.
Ending	The film does not provide a definitive supernatural or psychological explanation.

Actual audience-test results, screening feedback or evaluation scores are not specified in the supplied project information. If such evidence is required, it should be added as **[TO BE PROVIDED]**.

CHAPTER 19

CHALLENGES FACED

A major challenge in producing a psychological mystery with one actor is creating the sense of another presence without showing another performer. The solution is to use eye direction, pauses, framing and the empty space beside the protagonist.

Another challenge is maintaining mystery within a very short duration. Too much explanation would reduce ambiguity, while too little information could make the sequence difficult to follow. The story therefore uses a small number of concrete clues: the message, photograph, notebook and voice.

The final voice creates an additional production challenge because it must sound like the protagonist's voice while remaining clearly separate as an audio event. The recording and editing process must therefore preserve intelligibility without making the effect overly artificial.

Continuity between the first and final garden scenes is also important. Camera position, actor placement and the visibility of the empty space should be considered during filming.

Challenge	Approach
One visible actor	Use performance, framing and empty space to imply another presence.
Short duration	Remove unnecessary exposition and focus on essential clues.
Maintaining ambiguity	Avoid a definitive visual explanation.
Voice identity	Use the protagonist's own voice for the mysterious call.
Scene continuity	Mirror the opening and final bench composition.

CHAPTER 20

LEARNING OUTCOMES

The project provides practical learning in screenplay development, scene planning, acting, cinematography, sound design, editing and production organization.

A significant learning outcome is understanding how a story can communicate information through visual details rather than dialogue. The photograph, notebook and empty bench each provide narrative information without requiring another on-screen character.

The project also demonstrates the importance of restraint. Silence, a facial reaction or a repeated camera composition can be more appropriate for a psychological mystery than an elaborate visual effect.

Working with one actor and two locations also develops practical production planning. The limited setup requires careful use of available space and encourages attention to framing, continuity and performance.

The project further demonstrates how sound can create uncertainty. Reusing the protagonist's own voice as the mysterious caller changes the audience's understanding without requiring an additional visible character.

CHAPTER 21

EXPECTED OUTCOME

The expected outcome is a completed approximately three-minute psychological mystery short film titled **The Empty Bench**. The film is intended to engage the audience through a gradual shift from an apparently ordinary meeting to uncertainty about memory, identity and reality.

The final product should demonstrate how a minimal cast and limited locations can support an effective narrative when the visual composition, sound and editing are carefully planned.

The audience is expected to recognize the central emotional idea: sometimes letting go is harder than losing someone. However, the film should not force a single interpretation of the events.

The ending is successful for the project's purpose when it leaves the audience with the central question rather than resolving the mystery through a conventional explanation.

CHAPTER 22

FUTURE SCOPE

The film can be developed further without changing its central concept. Future versions could refine the screenplay timing, improve continuity between the two garden scenes and conduct controlled audience screenings to study how viewers interpret the ending.

If additional post-production resources are available, the soundscape can be refined while maintaining the film's restrained approach. The voice effect can also be adjusted to preserve the idea that the caller is the protagonist's own voice.

A future academic extension could include a structured audience-evaluation form measuring whether viewers identify the intended themes of loss, memory, attachment and reality versus perception. Such results are not part of the current supplied project information and should be added only after actual evaluation.

The story could also be adapted into an audio-only format in future work, but the present project remains a short film and does not assume a completed podcast production.

CHAPTER 23

CONCLUSION

The **The Empty Bench** project demonstrates how a short psychological mystery can be developed using one actor, two locations, minimal dialogue and a small number of narrative objects. The film uses the bench as a recurring visual symbol for absence, memory and attachment.

The story begins with a mysterious message and gradually connects the present with a loss from three years earlier. The photograph and notebook provide concrete clues, while the unknown call and the protagonist's own voice create uncertainty about identity and perception.

Cinematography, sound, silence and editing are treated as storytelling tools rather than decorative elements. In particular, the empty space beside the protagonist allows the audience to experience the absence without being shown a definite second character.

The final scene returns to the bench and intentionally refuses to provide a single explanation. The film therefore remains faithful to its central idea that emotional attachment can make letting go more difficult than loss itself.

Overall, **The Empty Bench** provides practical experience in developing, filming and editing a short narrative while demonstrating how ambiguity, restraint and visual repetition can be used to communicate a psychological theme.